Lesson 34 material: Reading Academic Articles and Writing an Annotated Bibliography

3.8: Reading Academic Articles for Research

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Academic and popular sources

When Lily started her research, she found many sources. Some were very short and quick to read, and others were extremely difficult. At first she felt overwhelmed trying to figure out which articles she needed to read, and which ones would be most useful for her paper. In order to answer that question for Lily's research (and yours), it's useful to think about what kinds of articles you can find in a database. Figure 3.8.1 shows a student doing research online.

(Picture: College student looking at a laptop with a serious expression)

Figure: "Working Outside" by CollegeDegrees360 is marked with CC BY-SA 2.0.

As you learned in 3.5: Finding Your Topic and Research Question, there are several kinds of sources in a database. The most common are academic sources and popular sources. Academic sources (also called scholarly sources) contain original research and are written for other academic readers. Popular sources include newspapers and magazines, and are written for a general audience.

Table 3.8.1 covers the characteristics of scholarly and popular sources

Table 3.8.1 Comparison of academic and popular sources by authors, readers, purpose, style, peer review, and citations

Feature	Academic	Popular
Content	Contains original research data such as scientific studies	Covers popular interest topics or summarizes research done by others
Authors	Expert scholars (professors or researchers with graduate degrees) with their credentials listed	Not experts, often journalists or writers
Readers	Scholars, researchers	General public
Purpose	To share research findings and expand knowledge	To inform or entertain
Style	Straightforward design with complex language	Flashy, eye catching design with accessible language
Citations	Contains citations	Few or no citations
Peer-review	Articles are peer-reviewed. This means that other scholars review the work to make sure that it is accurate.	Articles are not peer-reviewed.

Both kinds of sources can be useful in your research. Scholarly sources may have more specific and researched facts about your topic, while popular sources may contain current news and opinions or examples that you can use in your research paper. Check with your instructor to see if there are requirements about what kinds of sources to use for your own assignment.

Reading academic articles

You have already read a lot of popular sources and you already know how to read a general article and find information in it. However, reading academic articles is different. These are long and may feel very difficult at first. This guide will help you to understand the structure of an academic article and decide if it will work for your research question.

Parts of an academic journal article

Popular sources generally have one "story" from the beginning to the end. There may be subheadings to help you organize the main points, but those subheadings will be related to the information from the article.

Academic articles are different. They have a specific structure and each section is separate. Here are the most common sections that you will find in an academic article in the sciences or social sciences (although not every article will contain each section):

- Title: a concise and descriptive title. This lets you know what the article is about.
- Author Information: All authors who contributed to the article are listed. Often their affiliated institutions are included here or as a footnote.
- Abstract: a short summary of the article. The abstract should share the research findings.
- Introduction or Background: an overview of the research area that lays the foundation for the article's research.
- Methods or Methodology: This describes how the research study was performed.
- Results: a description of the results obtained. It presents the results without providing an interpretation. This often includes figures and tables.
- Discussion: This section analyses and interprets the results presented in the Results section. New data is never presented.
- Conclusion: This is a short section that summarizes the findings and significance of the article. The conclusion is omitted in some articles.

- References: A list of all articles cited in the article. This section is sometimes labeled Bibliography, Works Cited, or Literature Cited.

How to read each section

Now that you know the main parts of an academic article, you may wonder if you need to read each section in the same way, and if you need to read everything slowly and carefully.

The answer to this question is no! Academic sources can be very long and technical. It is easy to get lost in reading. For that reason, you should have a plan for reading and deciding what to use in an article. Table 3.8.2 gives some ideas of how to read each section.

Table 3.8.2 How to read each section of an academic article and questions to ask while reading

Part of the article	How to read	Questions to ask yourself while you are reading		
Title	Carefully	Is this topic related to my research question?		
Authors	Quickly	Do they have strong credentials that make them credible authors?		
Abstract	Carefully	What is the main point of their research or this article?	Is this related to my research question?	If you use this paper in your research, do not cite from the abstract. Instead, find the relevant part of the article.
Introduction	Somewhat carefully	Why are they doing their research?	How does this connect to my topic?	Can I cite this information to provide background for my own research paper?
Background or Literature Review	Carefully	What have others already said about my topic?	Can I cite this information to support a point in my own research paper?	
Methods or Methodology	Very quickly	This information is provided for other researchers who want to do a similar project or for people to evaluate whether or not the research study covered everything it needed to. It may be difficult to understand if you have not studied this field. That's okay. Just move on to the next section.		
Results	Very quickly	This is mostly for other researchers. Just move on to the next section.		
Discussion	Carefully	Can I understand and summarize this information?	What did the researchers learn?	Can I cite this information to support a point in my own research paper?
Conclusion	Carefully	Is their summary of the main points of this article the same as mine?	Can I cite this information to support a point in my own research paper?	
References	Very quickly	Is there anything else here that I want to read?		

Interactive Element

Let's try a real article

Lily found an academic article entitled "Development and Implementation of a Culturally Responsive Mentoring Program for Faculty and Staff of Color" in her library database. We're going to look at each part of it. As you listen, you can follow along with the article. Downloadable version of the article discussed in the video.

Watch this video to see how to analyze it.

(Online slides or activity: open the original page above.)

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Works Cited

Han, I., and A. J. Onchwari. "Development and Implementation of a Culturally Responsive Mentoring Program for Faculty and Staff of Color". *Interdisciplinary Journal of Partnership Studies*, vol. 5, no. 2, July 2018, p. Article 3, doi:10.24926/ijps.v5i2.1006.

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Table 3.8.1 was adapted from Scholarly and Popular Sources in *Library Skills for 2nd Year Biological Sciences* by Lauren Stieglitz. License: CC BY NC.

Bulleted list in "Parts of a Journal Article" was adapted from Anatomy of a Journal Article in *Library Skills for 2nd Year Biological Sciences* by Lauren Stieglitz. License: CC BY NC.

Article Han and Onchwari's article "Development and Implementation of a Culturally Responsive Mentoring Program for Faculty and Staff of Color" used in the video example is licensed CC BY NC.

Links on the original page

- “Development and Implementation of a Culturally Responsive Mentoring Program for Faculty and Staff of Color”: http://pubs.lib.umn.edu/index.php/ijps/article/view/1006

Attached: Downloadable version of the article discussed in the video.

A long document (8,465 words), not printed here. Open it from the original page above or from your computer's attachments folder (file: Downloadable_version_of_the_article_discussed_in_the_video..pdf). Your tutor has its full text.

3.9: Writing an Annotated Bibliography

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Writing an annotated bibliography

Your instructor may ask you to evaluate your sources by writing an annotated bibliography. We create annotated bibliographies in order to start researching and organizing sources before actually writing a research paper. Writing an annotated bibliography helps you to think critically about which sources you are using, how reliable they are, and how they will be useful.

The annotated bibliography is a list of sources that you may decide to use in your paper alone with extra notes (annotation). Each source, or entry, generally has two parts: a **complete citation** and a paragraph that includes both a **summary** and **evaluation.**

Summary

In the first sentence of your summary, include the **author's name + reporting verb, the main idea,** and the type of source (magazine, website, academic journal article, book, film, etc.).

Here are some sentence frames you can use for your summary:

- In this [*type of source]*, [*author's name*] explains [*main idea].*
- According to [*author's name*] in this [*type of source*]**,** [*main idea*].
- [*Author's name*] claims in this [*type of source]* that [*main idea*].

Evaluation

Here are some questions that you can think about as you write your evaluation:

- How credible is the source?
- Are there any biases?
- Why it is this relevant to your topic?
- How will you use it in your paper?

Here are some sentence frames you can use for your evaluation:

- This source seems credible because….
- This source may be considered biased because….
- The research strongly supports my research question because….
- I plan to use this in the [introduction/background/cause/effect, etc.] section of my paper to show….

Reading an annotated bibliography

As you read this sample annotated bibliography, think about these questions:

- Which strategies does the writer use to evaluate the article?
- What are strengths of this? How can it be improved?
- Does the writer have enough sources to support her thesis? Why or why not?
- Which sources seem strongest for supporting her point?
- Compare this annotated bibliography to the final research paper. Did the writer use all of these sources in her final draft? Why do you think this may be?

Sample Student Annotated Bibliography

Lily Liu De Li

Working thesis: Although minority faculty members play an important role on campuses, their contributions are often not recognized and colleges should find more ways to support and retain them.

Cleveland, Roger, et al. "Cultural Taxation." *Encyclopedia of Diversity and Social Justice*, edited by Sherwood Thompson, Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, 1st edition, 2014. *Credo Reference.*

Cleveland, et al. state in this encyclopedia article that minority faculty in the academic workplace face obstacles and prejudices. Diverse faculty are expected to take on extra roles to help the campus, which takes up time and increases their work pressure. This is an article from the Encyclopedia of Diversity and Social Justice which was published by Rowman & Littlefield. I chose this article because it will be used for one of my concessions.

Han, I., and A. J. Onchwari. "Development and Implementation of a Culturally Responsive Mentoring Program for Faculty and Staff of Color". *Interdisciplinary Journal of Partnership Studies*, vol. 5, no. 2, July 2018, p. Article 3, doi:10.24926/ijps.v5i2.1006.

In their academic article, Han and Onchwari describe a mentoring program that was set up to support faculty of color at a university that is mostly white. They first explain why it is important to have faculty of color and then review the problems that faculty of color face. Then, they explain how the mentoring program provided more of a community for the people who participated in it. This is a credible article because Han and Onchwari are professors of education and have studied this problem on their own campus. In addition, the article was published in an academic journal. I can use this in my

background of my paper to give evidence that faculty of color are underrepresented but serve a very important role. I can also use it in my paragraphs that look at solutions to the problem since mentoring seems very effective.

Johnson Barbara J., and Kyle J. Scafide. "Faculty Diversity." *Encyclopedia of Education,* edited by James W. Guthrie, 2nd ed., vol. 3, Macmillan Reference USA, 2002, pp. 775-779. Gale In Context: *Opposing Viewpoints.*

Johnson and Scafide claim in this encyclopedia article that to overcome the problems minority faculty face, campuses should make efforts to hire and retain them.This is an article from the Encyclopedia of Education (Vol.3. 2nd ed.) which was published by Gale. It seems unbiased and is written for an educated general audience. Barbara J. Johnson was a Professor of English and Comparative Literature and the Fredric Wertham Professor of Law and Psychiatry in Society at Harvard University. This article strongly supports my research question because it offers ideas about how the campus can deal with the problems that I discuss in my paper.

Peele, Thomas and Daniel J. Willis. “California's Failure to Diversify Community College Faculty Tied to Arcane State Law.” *EdSource*, 2 Mar. 2021.

Peele and Willis report on how there are few professors of color at California community colleges and how state laws for increasing faculty diversity are weak. They cite statistics about diversity and also quote from Latino college students to show why diversity is important. It also talks about causes, including the lack of candidates and low respect that community college professors get, and possible solutions. This is from a website that provides journalism about education in California. It is recent so the statistics are probably still up to date, and it is directly relevant to my research question. I will use this as background to demonstrate there there is a problem and to provide student voices in my article.

Reid, Pamela Trotman, and Sue Rosenberg Zalk. "Academic Environments: Gender and Ethnicity in U.S. Higher Education." *Encyclopedia of Women and Gender*: *Sex Similarities and Differences and the Impact of Society on Gender*, edited by Judith Worell, Elsevier Science & Technology, 1st edition, 2001. *Credo Reference.*

In this encyclopedia article, Pamela Reid and Sue Zalk suggest that minority faculty can overcome questioning their own abilities by building self-confidence and affirming their own capability. This is an article from the *Encyclopedia of Women and Gender: Sex Similarities and Differences and the Impact of Society on Gender,* so it mostly focuses on women but also connects their experiences with minority faculty. Pamela Reid Ph.D. is a developmental psychologist and the past President Emerita of the University of St. Joseph in Connecticut and Sue Rosenberg Zalk is a psychologist, so they have a background in this area. I choose this article because it explains "imposter syndrome," which may affect some minority members of the field. I am considering addressing this syndrome as one of the challenges facing faculty members.

Valeri, Mauro. "Ethnic Minority." *Dictionary of Race, Ethnicity & Culture,* Guido Bolaff, et al., Sage UK, 1st edition, 2003. *Credo Reference.*

According to this reference article by Mauro Valeri, minority group members have less representation and power than people of the majority group. This is an article from the dictionary of Race, Ethnicity & Culture, so it seems scholarly. Mauro Valeri is a sociologist and university professor. This article shares some issues related to minority representation that I may use to set the scene in the background part of my introduction.

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Sample Annotated Biography written by Lily Liu De Li. License: CC BY.

3.10: Language Toolkit

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Terms and Vocabulary for Research

- Search engine: A program that searches the internet, such as Google or Baidu
- Database: A collection of articles that is owned by a library
- Key word: Words that describe the main topic you are looking for
- Subject terms: words or phrases that describe the content of an article in the database. These are assigned by the database, and each database has a specific list of subject terms
- Narrow a search: make your search more specific so you find fewer, more focused articles
- Broaden a search: make your search less specific so you find more articles
- Current: recent or relating to today
- Credible: something that can be trusted

Getting help from a librarian (or instructor)

Research is not something that you need to do alone! Librarians' jobs are to help you, so please take advantage of working with them. Once you have a relationship with a librarian, you will be able to come back to the same person throughout your college career.

Table 3.10.2 gives some phrases you can use to ask for help from a librarian or instructor.

Table 3.10.2: Sentence starters and phrases to use in contacting a librarian or instructor

Sentence starter	Gerund + research task												
I need some help with	I would like some advice for....	I was wondering if you could assist me with...	I am having trouble with...	Coming up with a good research topic	Narrowing down my topic	Developing a strong research question	Using the databases	Using the internet to find strong sources	Finding key word synonyms	Narrowing down my search results	Evaluating my search results	Finding academic sources	Citing this information correctly

It is also helpful to share what you have already done. That way, the librarian will understand where you are in the process and how much you already know.

Let's look at a sample email:

Notice this!

What do you notice in this email that makes it more effective?

Dear Ms. Yap,

I am a student in ESOL 52 and I am working on a research paper on how faculty of color are underrepresented in colleges. I have already narrowed down my topic and I found a lot of sources in the library database. However, I am having trouble evaluating which sources are best for my paper. I was wondering if you could assist me with making sure that I have best sources?

Sincerely,

Lily

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3.11: Takeaways

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Summary

In this chapter we:

- Identified the reasons for writing a research paper and explained how to build a research mindset.
- Chose a research topic and developed a strong research question.
- Compared research methods and strategies and discussed how you can choose a research strategy for your paper.
- Evaluated different kinds of sources and discussed how to select the kinds of sources that will work for your paper.

Questions for reflection

- How do you do research in your everyday life? How is it similar or different to the process of researching for a paper?
- What was your path to research? Did you have a clear straight line or was it a messy circle? Go back and look at the linear vs. messy representations in 3.4: Research Process. If you like, try drawing your own research path.
- For you, what are the biggest challenges in doing research for a paper?
- How did your thinking about your topic change through the research?
- What resources (websites, tools, or people) did you find that you can use to help with your next research project?
- Look back at 3.2: Sample Student Research Essay: Faculty of Color and 3.9: Writing an Annotated Bibliography. How did creating an annotated bibliography help the writer develop her research essay?

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